

THE MULTIVERSE

Countless Universes of Heroes

The mainstream Marvel Universe is only one of countless possible universes in the multiverse. Most full universes are known by the name "Earth" attached to an identifying number. The regular Marvel Universe is Earth-616, although almost no one in that universe knows of it as anything other than "home." Many of the universes have their own versions of familiar characters, although they may be drastically different from each other. Most people live their lives in a single universe, never knowing anything of places beyond their own. A rare few, however, travel between the universes frequently. We live on Earth-1218.



EARTH X

The future of Earth-9997 is a dark time. Black Bolt has released the Terrigen Mists into the atmosphere, causing many humans to become mutants. Controlling the US food supply, Norman Osborn (Green Goblin) makes himself US President and has Iron Man build robotic versions of the Avengers for him. The new Galactus (Franklin Richards) eventually saves the world. Later, Captain Mary-Vell persuades

Thanos to use the Ultimate Nullifier on Death, then helps to make Mr. Fantastic—who has built a Paradise for the dead in the Negative Zone—into the new Eternity.

The transparent Machine Man served as the eyes for Earth X's Watcher.

EXILES

The Exiles are a Super Hero team assembled by the mysterious Timebroker to solve problems in the multiverse. The Timebroker is actually part of an insectoid alien race that is trying to repair the damage it did to the multiverse. The creatures live in the Panoptichron, a transdimensional space from which they can monitor several other realities at once. The leader of the Exiles uses a device called a Talus to communicate with the Timebroker, helping to keep the team on track. Due to the dangerous nature of their jobs, the Exiles have a high turnover rate, but there are always replacements ready to take the place of the fallen.



1602

In an alternate world (Earth-460), the Purple Man uses his powers of persuasion to become US President and exiles Captain America into the past of Earth-311. This disrupts that universe's timeline so badly that modern heroes begin to appear at the turn of the 17th century; for instance, Sir Nicholas Fury works for Queen Elizabeth of England. Later, after the timeline has been fixed by the removal of Captain America, many of the heroes move to the New World, which is populated by dinosaurs along with the native peoples.



Alternate versions of regular heroes and villains band together to save the multiverse as the Exiles.



ULTIMATES

On Earth-1610, the heroes who have been around the mainstream universe for decades have just developed, and sometimes have done so in unique ways. Spider-Man, for instance, is just a teenager in high school. Nick Fury is African-American—although he still wears an eye patch—and the Avengers are known as the Ultimates. There are far fewer superpowered people in this world, and the number was recently reduced when Magneto went on a murderous rampage to avenge the deaths of Quicksilver and the Scarlet Witch and flooded New York City with a tidal wave.



Until recently, the Ultimate universe seemed like a younger version of Earth-616, but it has now diverged in important and substantial ways.

SQUADRON SUPREME

One of the most enduring crossovers between universes happened when the Avengers traveled to Earth-712 and met the top hero team there, the Squadron Supreme. Years later, the Squadron's members decided to try taking over and running the world, but when this went bad they exiled themselves to Earth-616. They returned to find their homeworld overrun by ruthless corporations. They've also had encounters with people from the Ultimate universe (Earth-1610) and a darker version of their own team from Earth-31916.



WHAT IF...

The WATCHER often travels to different universes that are extremely close to Earth-616 but diverge at one critical point or another, such as "What if Uncle Ben had lived?" Sometimes he visits universes in which a regular hero appears in a different time, like Captain America as a fighter in the Revolutionary War. Other times, the issues the Watcher examines are more complex and posit a series of different paths taken during massive events like the Civil War (see pp. 84-5) or the Secret Invasion (see pp. 326-7).

ZOMBIES

A zombie version of the Sentry entered Earth-2149 and, with the help of Magneto, began infecting superpowered people with a virus that turned them into the living dead. Magneto mistakenly thought the infection would only harm humans, leaving mutants alive. The zombies retain most of their powers, but their hunger for human flesh regularly overpowers them. After they run out of food, the superpowered zombies try traveling to new universes filled with fresh meat. They have managed to reach Earth-1610 and Earth-616 universes.

